

Chapter 06: Marriage

Brief Summary

This chapter revises Vaillant's earlier view that divorce was a strong sign of poor mental health. With much longer follow-up, he concludes that the key issue is not divorce itself but the capacity to love well over time. Some first marriages remain happy, some long marriages remain emotionally thin or unhappy, and some remarriages after divorce become deeply successful. The chapter also identifies alcoholism as the hidden variable that explains much marital damage.

Key Study Findings

- By 2010, 173 first marriages remained intact: 51 happy, 73 average, and 49 unhappy.
- Twenty-three divorced men had very happy remarriages that lasted, on average, almost thirty-five years.
- Earlier data made divorce look like a direct marker of poor adjustment. Later data showed that this was often premature and confounded by alcoholism.
- The single most important factor in Grant Study divorces was alcoholism. Thirty-four divorces, or 57 percent, occurred when at least one spouse abused alcohol.
- Once alcoholism was controlled, earlier supposed causes of divorce - poor coping, shaky mental health, and weak relationship skills - lost much of their predictive force.
- Alcohol generally made marriages worse rather than bad marriages causing alcoholism. Vaillant found many more cases where happy marriages deteriorated after alcohol abuse began than the reverse.
- Marital happiness increased with age. Only about 18 percent of marriages were happy for at least twenty years between early adulthood and seventy; by eighty-five, 76 percent of surviving marriages were rated happy.
- Good father relationships were linked to better lifelong marriages, more humor, less anxiety, and better retirement adjustment.
- Fear of sex predicted poor mental health more strongly than sexual dissatisfaction within marriage.

Interesting Stories And Examples

- Fredrick and Catherine Chipp show a durable happy marriage that remains lively through teasing, shared dependence, and adjustment to each other's changes.
- John Adams shows that repeated divorce does not prevent later intimacy. His fourth marriage, begun in midlife, becomes a long and genuinely happy partnership.
- Eben and Patricia Frost represent the limits of 'so-so' marriages: stable, orderly, and not openly destructive, but lacking deep intimacy and shared joy.
- The memorable wife who answered 'Divorce, never. Murder, frequently' captures the chapter's warm realism about long marriage.

Why It Matters

The chapter is a useful corrective for adult development theory. Staying married is not automatically healthy, divorce is not automatically pathological, and alcoholism must be treated as a major causal force in marital research.